

INDEPENDENT M&E REVIEW SERIES · BRIEF 3

Feeding the Bet

An Independent M&E Review of Nigeria's Home-Grown School Feeding Programme, 2016–2025

₦186bn

Claimed cumulative expenditure 2016–2020

9.99M

Peak pupils claimed (2022)

34

Curated sources analyzed

5

Indicator recommendations

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Nigeria's National Home-Grown School Feeding Programme committed the federal government to a deceptively simple wager: that a daily mid-day meal costing **₦70 per child** would simultaneously increase school enrolment, improve child nutrition, stimulate smallholder agriculture, and create over one million jobs. At its **2022 peak, the programme claimed 9,990,862 pupils across 53,000+ schools and 127,000 cooks**. Those figures are real. No public verification framework exists to confirm them — and no per-state or per-quarter delivery record has been released for any programme year after 2020.

On **12 January 2024, President Tinubu suspended the programme**, stranding 9 million+ pupils and disrupting 250,000 jobs (Guardian Nigeria, 2025). As of mid-2026, programmes have not been fully resumed despite presidential approval granted on 21 January 2025 — a gap of more than seventeen months between approval and resumption. This brief document four structural measurement failures that made this crisis both undetectable and unverifiable.

CORE FINDINGS

FINDING 1 — THE BUDGET ARITHMETIC THAT DOES NOT RECONCILE

₦33.8 Billion of Public Money Has No Public Explanation

F1

The House Committee on Public Accounts scrutinized **₦186 billion in claimed cumulative NHGSFP expenditure to 2020**. The component figures disclosed — ₦63.2bn (2018), ₦32.2bn (2019), ₦124.4bn (2020) — sum to ₦219.8bn, leaving a **₦33.8bn discrepancy that no public document reconciles**. Of the ₦186bn headline, the Committee was told only **₦64bn reached direct feeding**, meaning 66 per cent went to overheads, administration, and unspecified uses. The Committee described this as outrageous and unacceptable. A full audit was demanded. No public audit report has been released in the six years since that demand.

Qualitative follow-up needed: Can a Freedom of Information filing unlock the missing ₦33.8bn reconciliation? What budget-head reclassification explains the gap — and which ministry owns the answer?

FINDING 2 — THE ₦70 QUESTION: SILENT INFLATION EROSION

The Programme Has Been Buying Less Food Every Year Without a Budget Decision

The ₦70 per-child-per-meal rate was set at launch in 2016 and held through the January 2024 suspension. Nigeria's Food CPI rose by approximately 150 per cent between 2016 and 2024. By 2025, the nominal ₦70 retains the food-purchasing power of **approximately ₦11 in 2016 terms — less than one-sixth of its launch value**. The WFP regional benchmark is \$0.30–\$0.50 per child per day. At ₦100 and a 2024 exchange rate of ₦1,500 per dollar, Nigeria's allocation equates to roughly **\$0.07 — between 14 and 23 per cent of the minimum regional benchmark**. President Buhari approved an increase to ₦100 in 2022; it was never implemented before the suspension. NSIPA's 2025 target of ₦500–₦1,000 per child, applied to a 50-million-pupil ambition, implies daily outlays of ₦25–₦50 billion with no gazette indexation rule.

F2

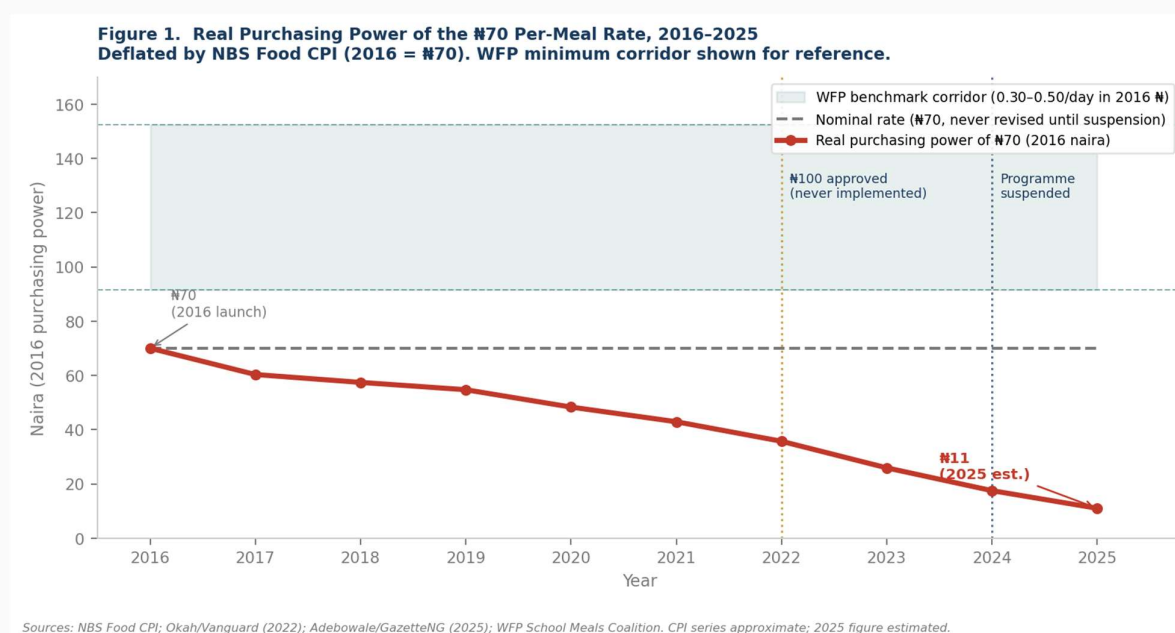


Figure 1. Real purchasing power of the ₦70 per-meal rate, 2016–2025 (indexed to 2016 = ₦70), with WFP benchmark corridor

Qualitative follow-up needed: Why was the ₦100 approval (2022) never implemented in disbursement? What political economy prevents automatic indexation — and what comparable instrument in Nigeria's fiscal architecture could anchor it?

FINDING 3 — DELIVERY BOTTLENECKS AND THE FRAUD TIMELINE

Three Failure Modes Recur Across States and Administrations

F3

Phantom beneficiary lists: In Kogi State (ICPC, 2019), **₦68m was diverted through cooks' accounts placed on lien without their knowledge**. Funds were transferred to 10 company accounts for food supplies never delivered. Nasarawa State later uncovered **349 'ghost schools'** falsely listed as programme beneficiaries (Nairametrics, 2025).

Cook stipend arrears: The programme's claimed cook workforce of **107,862–126,000** includes no attrition tracking, no stipend-payment verification record, and no grievance mechanism for non-payment. When arrears accumulate, cooks absorb the cost through unpaid labor or reduced meal quality.

State co-financing gaps: NHGSFP design assigns federal government responsibility for Primary 1–3 and state government responsibility for Primary 4–6. In practice, **no state co-financing readiness assessment has ever been published.** The 2023 Kebbi suspension (₦8.8 billion in unauthorized procurement) illustrates the fragility underlying national reach figures.

The fraud timeline compounds: the ₦68m Kogi incident (2019) and the **₦30bn+ NSIPA seizure (December 2025)** are separated by three orders of magnitude — not because the programme deteriorated, but because small undetected diversions compound when no systematic verification mechanism exists.

Qualitative follow-up needed: *How many cooks are still owed stipends from pre-2024 arrears? Which states have co-financed their Primary 4–6 obligation — and which have not? Can CSO validation (as in 2019) be scaled nationally?*

FINDING 4 — THE MEASUREMENT BLIND SPOT: A GOVERNANCE CHOICE

The Programme Cannot Answer: 'How Many Children Received a Meal Today?'

F4

There is no publicly accessible NHGSFP dashboard. There is no quarterly state-level report of pupils fed for any period from 2020 onwards. There is no published reconciliation of funds released against meals served for any programme year. The WFP School Meals Coalition database records **10 million pupils receiving meals in 2023**. Tribune Online (Akintola, 2025) confirms programmes were **still not resumed as of late 2025 — more than seventeen months after presidential approval**. Two reputable bodies are irreconcilable on the same programmatic period. This is not a data problem. It is a governance decision.

The data infrastructure exists: NSIPA has an MIS. The programme uses a mobile-verification application. The NEDI digital platform has onboarded 21 states. What does not exist is the political decision to make the data public. World Bank/NASSCO (2025) quantifies the consequence: Nigeria's social protection spending produces **'almost no impact' on poverty** — 0.14 per cent of GDP against a Sub-Saharan Africa average of 1.1 per cent, with only 44 per cent of benefits reaching the poor.

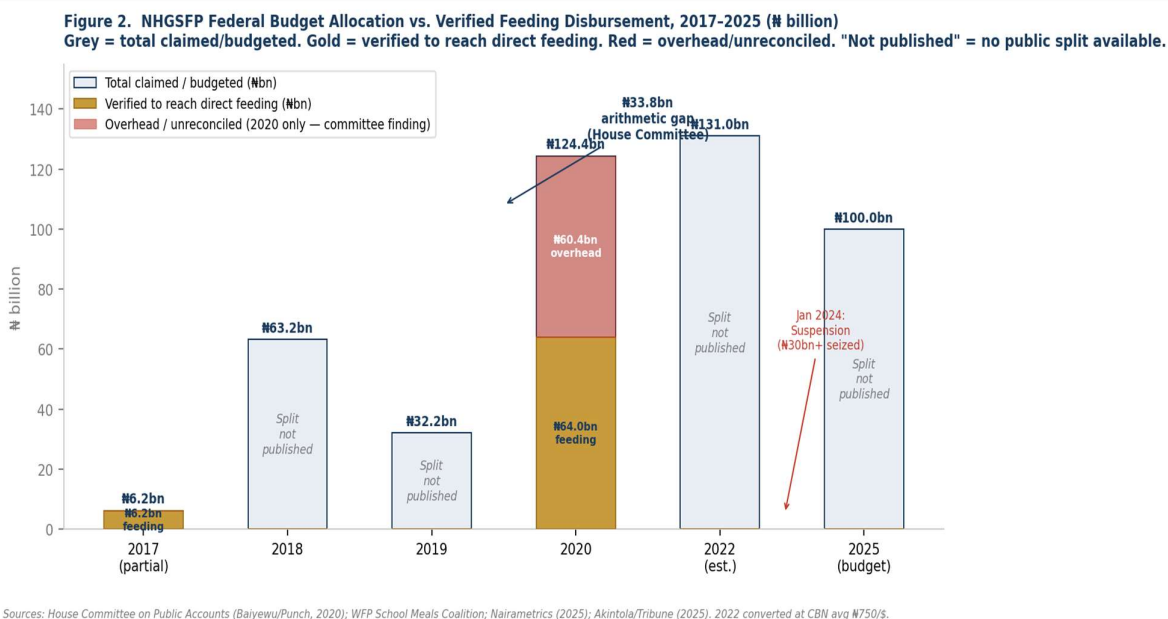


Figure 2. NHGSFP budget allocation vs. verified feeding disbursement, 2016–2024 (₦ billion)

Qualitative follow-up needed: Is the governance decision not to publish data a ministerial, NSIPA, or inter-agency failure? What accountability instrument — parliamentary, judicial, or civic — is most likely to compel publication in Nigeria's institutional context?

FRAMEWORK RECOMMENDATIONS

RECOMMENDATION 1

PUBLIC QUARTERLY DASHBOARD

NSIPA to publish state-level pupil counts and naira disbursements within 30 days of each quarter-end, disaggregated by state, LGA, and school. BudgIT Foundation has demonstrated the template; the NEDI platform (21 states) provides the infrastructure. Feasible within 90 days; no legislation required.

RECOMMENDATION 2

INDEPENDENT VERIFICATION LINE ITEM

Ring-fence at least 1 per cent of NHGSFP annual budget for independent third-party verification by accredited Nigerian CSOs. Precedent: the ANEEJ CSO coalition verified SIPs in 2019. At ₦100bn appropriation, 1% = ₦1bn — less than a single fraud incident. Include in 2027 appropriation.

RECOMMENDATION 3

BIOMETRIC COOK REGISTRY

Digitize the full cook registry with biometric anchoring to National Identification Numbers (NIN) before any re-expansion. The Kogi fraud (₦68m) was enabled by account manipulation; NIN-linked payment accounts prevent recurrence. N-Power biometric registration provides the technical precedent. Pilot 10,000 cooks in two states within 180 days.

RECOMMENDATION 4

AUTOMATIC UNIT-COST REVIEW TRIGGER

Embed a unit-cost review clause in NHGSFP appropriation legislation: a reviewed rate must be submitted to the National Assembly within 60 days whenever NBS Food CPI exceeds 25 per cent growth from the preceding review baseline. NBS publishes monthly CPI; the trigger requires only a legislative clause. Include in the 2026 Finance Act.

RECOMMENDATION 5

STATE CO-FINANCING READINESS AUDIT

Publish a co-financing readiness score for each participating state annually across four dimensions: budget commitment, payment infrastructure, school-survey coverage, and MIS integration. Make federal disbursements to states conditional on minimum readiness thresholds before any expansion toward the 50-million-pupil target. Rwanda phased transition model (WFP/USDA, 2026) demonstrates feasibility.

CROSS-CUTTING NOTE

All five recommendations should be disaggregated by state, gender, and household wealth quintile. The school feeding programme claimed equity rationale cannot be verified without equity-stratified monitoring. International comparators (Rwanda, Ghana) embed M&E at design stage; Nigeria programme has operated for eight years without a published M&E budget line.

NOTES ON THE PROGRAMME'S DOCUMENTED ACHIEVEMENTS

This brief has been analytical and critical in posture — the appropriate register for an independent M&E review. It is equally important to situate the measurement gaps within a programme that has also generated documented positive effects at substantial scale.

11–42% Relative enrolment gains A 2025 scoping review of eight qualifying studies finds 11–42 percentage-point relative enrolment increases attributable to NHGSFP across evaluated sites. The width of that range reflects M&E inconsistency, not programme failure.	3.8× Geographic scale-up in 5 years From 14 states and 2.8 million pupils in August 2017 to claimed coverage of 33+ states and nearly 10 million pupils by 2022 — a fourfold expansion in geographic footprint, a delivery achievement of real institutional significance.	127k+ Community cooks at peak The cook-employment pathway — engaging predominantly women as local food preparers with stipend income — is one of the few NHGSFP mechanisms with documented positive secondary effects on women's economic participation (Okah, 2022; Majeed, 2021).	40% vs 20% Food security: beneficiary vs. non-beneficiary farmers The 2025 scoping review finds 40% food security among smallholder farmers engaged in NHGSFP procurement versus 20% among non-beneficiary farmers — a two-to-one advantage that, if sustained at scale, represents a genuine agricultural poverty-reduction effect.
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The argument of this brief is not that these achievements are insufficient or should not be recognized. The argument is that they **cannot be fully credited or attributed to specific programme mechanisms without a verification architecture capable of distinguishing genuine programme-induced effects from selection effects, reporting inflation, and input-activity confounds**. A programme that achieves 11–42 per cent enrolment gains in eight qualifying studies but cannot tell us how many of its 10 million claimed beneficiaries actually received meals last month is a programme whose real achievements remain, in the M&E sense, unmeasured.

METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

This brief is a secondary analysis of **34 publicly available sources** covering Nigeria's NHGSFP from 2016 to 2025: official government portals, World Bank and UN assessments, legislative oversight reports (House Committee on Public Accounts; House Committee on Special Duties), ICPC fraud investigations, investigative journalism (Punch, Premium Times, Vanguard, Guardian Nigeria, Tribune Online, BusinessDay), peer-reviewed academic studies, and civic data platforms (BudgIT Foundation). No primary fieldwork was undertaken. Where sources conflict — particularly on beneficiary counts and budget disbursements — the contradiction is named rather than resolved. Inflation deflation uses NBS Food CPI annual averages indexed to 2016. Currency conversion for WFP figures uses the CBN 2023 annual average rate of approximately ₦750/\$. Readers seeking primary data are directed to the CGIAR/IFPRI Osun State baseline study and the ANEEJ/NSIO Social Protection Baseline Report.

CLOSING ARGUMENT

Nigeria's NHGSFP is Africa's largest school feeding programme by claimed scale. It has generated documented enrolment gains, smallholder procurement effects, and women's economic inclusion through cook employment. It has also produced a budget arithmetic that does not reconcile, a fraud timeline that compounds from **₦68 million in 2019 to ₦30 billion in 2025**, and a reporting silence that has left **9 million children's daily meal status unverifiable for more than two years**.

The programme measures what it does — funds released, cooks engaged, schools covered — with partial precision for administrative accountability. It does not measure the conditions that determine whether those inputs convert into outcomes: whether cooks received their stipends on time, whether meals met the nutrient standard the unit cost implies, whether pupils whose enrolment was recorded actually attended and ate, and whether financial flows authorized in the budget arrived at their intended destinations.

The five recommendations in this brief are not ambitious redesigns. They are the **minimum conditions** under which a programme with a ₦100 billion 2025 appropriation, a 50-million-pupil target, and international commitments to feed 20 million children by 2026 can know — and demonstrate — whether it is feeding the children it claims to feed. The programme's bet on a daily meal was always theoretically sound. The M&E system capable of verifying whether the bet is paying off has yet to be built. This brief is the specification for that system.

INDEPENDENT M&E REVIEWS OF NIGERIAN SOCIAL INVESTMENT PROGRAMMES

Brief 1: NASSP Household Uplifting Programme · Brief 2: AGILE Adolescent Girls Education · Brief 3: NHGSFP School Feeding (this brief)

Full brief, source matrix, and all references: github.com/Almuarif17/social-protection-me-nigeria